areas, it had a large RSS shakha presence, a cadre and some centres of influence. Somewhat like the Idgah Maidan movement in Karnataka, the BJP spearheaded the Sabarimala movement in Kerala against the Supreme Court's judgement allowing women pilgrims to the holy site, although it did not yield political dividends. However, the agitation did help create a ground-base for the party, so that it emerged from the whole controversy as a player. In the future, given the right conditions, this could be the basis for political advances—that is, if the Congress declines, as has happened in other states like West Bengal and Assam.

Rajeev Chandrashekhar summed it up thus: 'If you look at the history of BJP, its leaders have been traditionally north Indian leaders. They started in pockets in the North and expanded into the Hindi belt. Meanwhile, we have built a significant Sangh Parivar presence in the South. Political activity and the political momentum in the South was very belated and it began only in the late 1990s. There were a lot of reasons for this, including linguistic problems for BJP. South and north India are very different places. While there was considerable bench strength for the BJP in the North, the development of BJP's political leaders in the South was really a 1990s phenomena when you had a Yediyurappa and an Ananth Kumar that built the party in Karnataka and made it electorally successful here. Now, if we can find such leaders in other states, we have the basis for expansion, the opportunity and the timing.'[126]